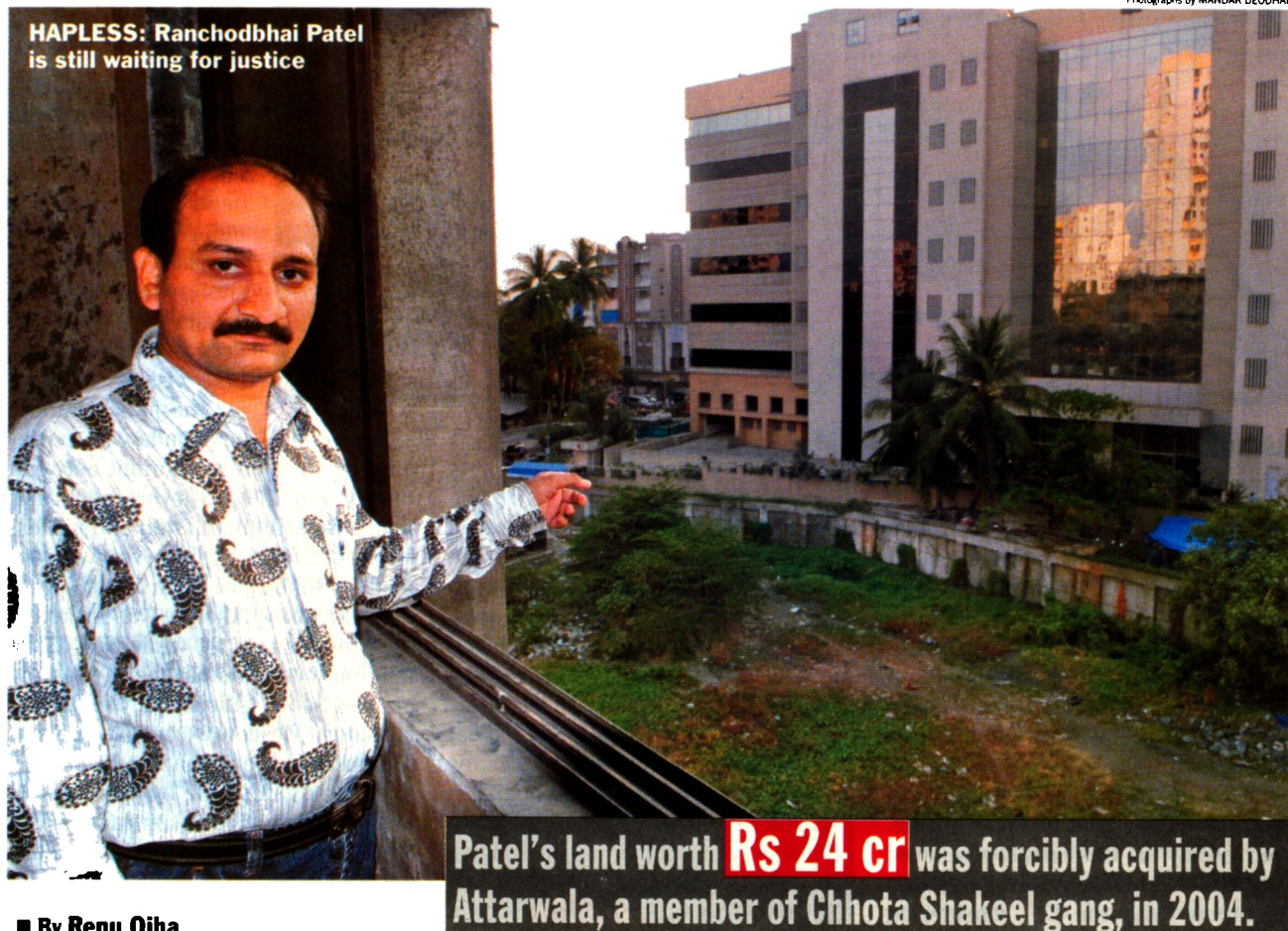


Slime and Mortar

The underworld is using local builders to make the most of Mumbai's redevelopment. The scramble for space is no longer between those who need a roof but between those who want to build it.

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR



HAPLESS: Ranchodbhai Patel is still waiting for justice

Patel's land worth **Rs 24 cr** was forcibly acquired by Attarwala, a member of Chhota Shakeel gang, in 2004.

■ By Renu Ojha

Exactly three years ago, Ranchodbhai Patel returned to Mumbai from Ahmedabad to find someone else occupying the 2,400 sq m of land he owned in Malad, a Mumbai suburb. Shocked, Patel did what any sensible man would have done: he went to the police to register a case. "For 17 days, I ran from pillar to post to get an FIR registered. Even after the complaint was lodged, the police acted very casually. I guessed from their behaviour that they were being influenced by someone powerful," he says.

He had guessed it right. On November 27, 2004, armed goons led by Iqbar Attarwala, a member of the Chhota Shakeel gang, had forcibly occupied the property. In just

a few hours, all traces that the land, worth Rs 24 crore, ever belonged to Patel were removed and a new nameplate was put up indicating that it now belonged to "Sherjill Builders". Forged documents and signatures completed the transaction.

Since then, Patel and his family have been living under a constant threat from Shakeel and though the Mumbai Police last month arrested four builders, the intimidation continues. With no help from the police, Patel filed a writ petition in the high court requesting a CBI enquiry. It was only after CBI's intervention that the case picked up some momentum and Attarwala was arrested in October. "After three years of battling

underworld threats and offers for out-of-court settlement, we are hoping that justice, though delayed, will not be denied," says Patel. In another case, the police arrested builders Alpeesh Ajmera and Bachi Singh for threatening, extorting and grabbing an 11,000 sq m property in Andheri.

The Mumbai Police's suspicion about a builder-underworld nexus was confirmed in October when the crime branch arrested Singh and Riyaz Bhati, Umesh Gandhi and Mahendra Verma, and charged them with having close ties with the underworld involved in land grabbing. While Gandhi and Verma are builders, the other two are a part of the underworld.

With Mumbai going in for massive